Hebrews and James

Hebrews 1, 4, 10–12 · James 1–2

The big idea: Hebrews tells believers tempted to drift back that Jesus is better: his one offering finished the work, and he sympathizes with our weakness. James tells believers whose faith did nothing that faith without works is dead. We are justified by faith alone, but saving faith is never alone.

Before you meet: Read

Hebrews 4:14–16 | Hebrews 10:11–25 | James 2:14–26

Open (5 minutes)

When you are under pressure, what do you tend to drift toward or fall back on?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of _____, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need." *(Hebrews 4:16)*

"Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not _____." *(Hebrews 11:1)*

"So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is _____." *(James 2:17)*

Discuss

1. Why does it matter that the priests stood daily, but Christ sat down? *Hebrews 10:11–14*

2. Jesus was tempted in every way, yet without sin. How does that change the way you pray? *Hebrews 4:14–16*

3. How would you explain to a friend how Paul and James fit together on faith and works? *James 2:14–26; Romans 3:28*

Memory verse

"Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need."

Hebrews 4:16

Pray

Thank Jesus that he is the better High Priest who offered himself once for all and always lives to intercede. Draw near to him with whatever you are carrying. Ask for a faith that works by love, and pray for someone who is suffering.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 49

Hebrews and James

Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Hebrews 10:11–25 and James 2:14–26 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (1 Peter 1:3–9 and 4:12–19, 1 John 1:5–2:2 and 4:7–21, and Jude 24–25).

Main points to land

1. Jesus is better than angels, Moses, the priests, and the sacrifices. His one offering finished the work, and he always lives to intercede (Hebrews 1:1–3; 7:25; 10:11–14).
2. Because our High Priest sympathizes with our weakness, we may draw near to the throne of grace with confidence (Hebrews 4:14–16; 10:19–22).
3. We are justified by faith alone, but saving faith is never alone; it shows itself in works of love (James 2:14–26; Romans 3:28; WCF 11.2).

Core doctrine to teach

Sanctification and Perseverance CORE DOCTRINE 25 OF 26

Those God justifies, he also makes holy. Sanctification is the Spirit's lifelong work of making us more like Christ, as we put sin to death and grow in love and obedience. It is never finished in this life, but God will finish it. Everyone truly joined to Christ will persevere to the end, because he keeps them. *Philippians 1:6; 2:12–13; Hebrews 12:14; 1 Peter 1:5; Jude 24*

Answer key (Observe)

1. grace
2. seen
3. dead

Questions people will ask

Do Paul and James contradict each other?

No. Paul answers people who think they can earn God's acceptance: we are declared righteous by faith alone (Romans 3:28). James answers people who claim faith but live as if Christ makes no difference: real faith shows itself in works (James 2:18). Paul speaks of the root, James of the fruit.

Closing prayer

Lord Jesus, our great High Priest, you offered yourself once for all and you sympathize with our weakness. Keep us from drifting. Give us a faith that works by love, and make us doers of your word. We draw near to your throne of grace. Amen.